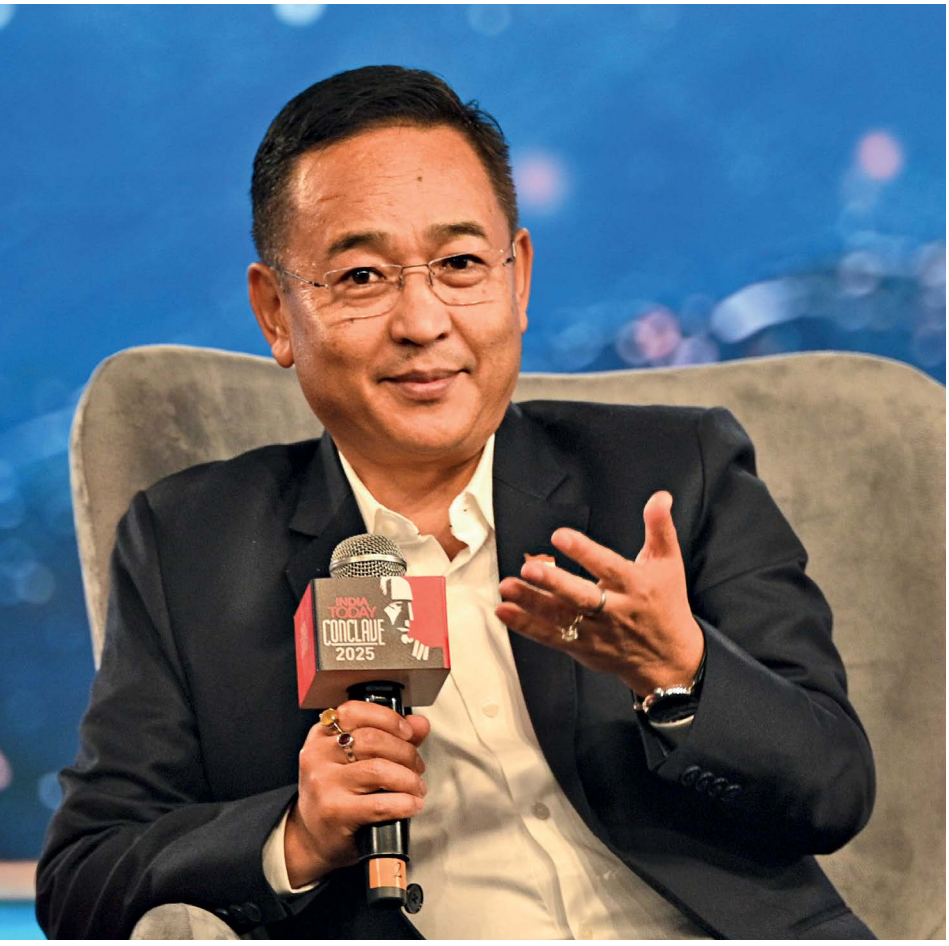


ARUN KUMAR

PREM SINGH TAMANG
Chief Minister, Sikkim

Before 2014, the Northeast was merely a 'political platform'. But now, it has transformed to become a 'development platform'. There is no paucity of funds for projects

It is a historic year for Sikkim, we are completing 50 years of becoming India's 22nd state... We will celebrate it for a whole year after the inauguration by the PM

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- The infrastructure that has come up in the past 10 years, including rail and road networks, has transformed the Northeast
- The improved connectivity—physical and digital—has laid the foundation for unleashing the region's potential
- The next target is 'soft development', gains in the education, health and tourism sectors to make the Northeast the country's most vibrant region
- The Northeast states are now looking to emulate the 'Sikkim model'. The state now has the highest per capita income in the country
- Environmental degradation is a big worry in the region, with Arunachal Pradesh the worst affected
- The Manipur crisis, still simmering after close to two years, is admittedly a blot, but the Centre is striving to bring about a lasting peace

Sikkim, including an alternative route to NH-10 and a railway connection, which is expected by 2027. Of course, a few persistent challenges remain, such as relative poverty, deforestation and the continuing crisis in Manipur. The Northeast has been particularly plagued by deforestation, with the Union minister admitting that some areas have been severely affected, especially in Arunachal Pradesh, which has the largest forest cover in the country. The two leaders were hopeful that the Supreme Court ruling banning tree felling would improve the situation.

Regarding the violence in Manipur which is now nearing the two-year mark, Rijiju called it an "unfortunate" crisis. He cited the Union government's hands-on approach, and pointed out that since President's Rule was declared, there have been very few incidents of violence. He said he was very hopeful that with the support and cooperation of all the factions, peace and normalcy would return to Manipur very soon. ■

To watch the full session, visit https://bitly.cx/prDhz